
East Midlands Airport

Plane Spotting Guide

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Active Runway

Depending on the weather, planes will land on a side of the one runway. There is Runway 27 and there is Runway 09. If you are going plane spotting you will need to know which side of the runway the plane will be landing from. To find this out, you can go to [this website](#)

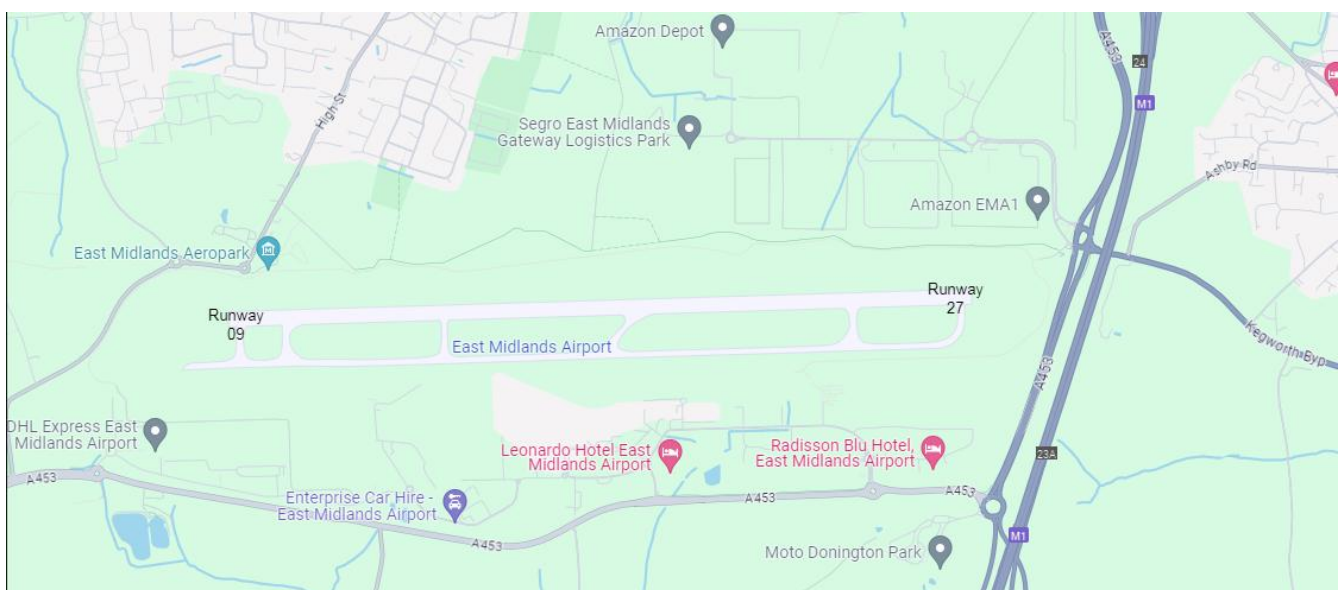
Then once you are there, find this table

Runways				
Id	Heading	Crosswind	Headwind	Crosswind %
9/27	088°-268°	← 4 kt	9 kt	37 %

You can see that the active runway in this scenario is Runway 09. This will mean that planes will depart from 09 and also land onto 09.

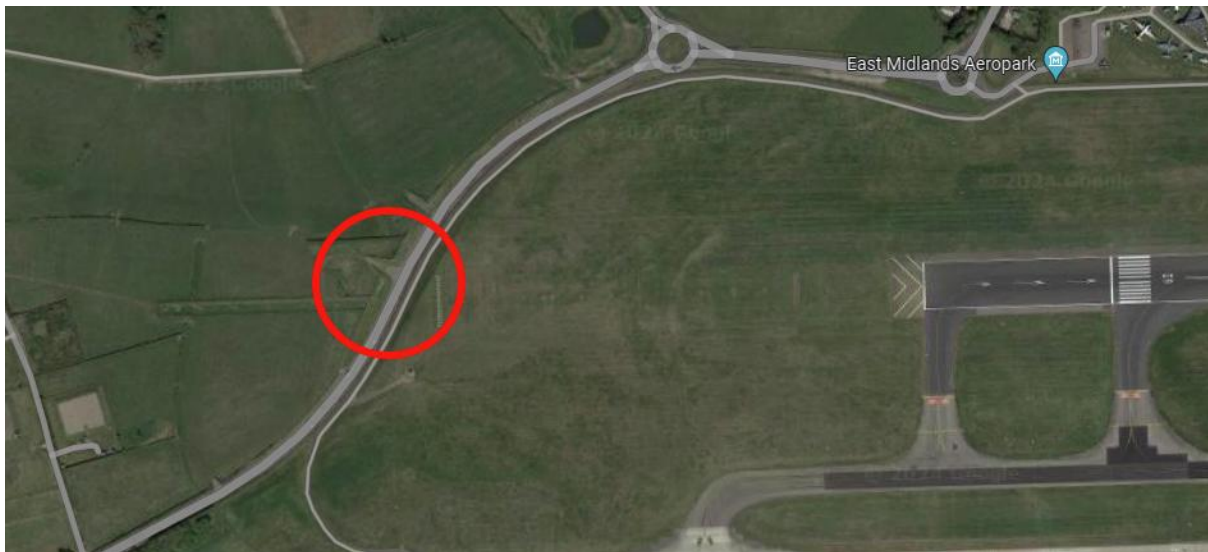
If 27 was bold, that would mean that the active runway is 27 and planes will land and depart on Runway 27

Here is a map of the airport.



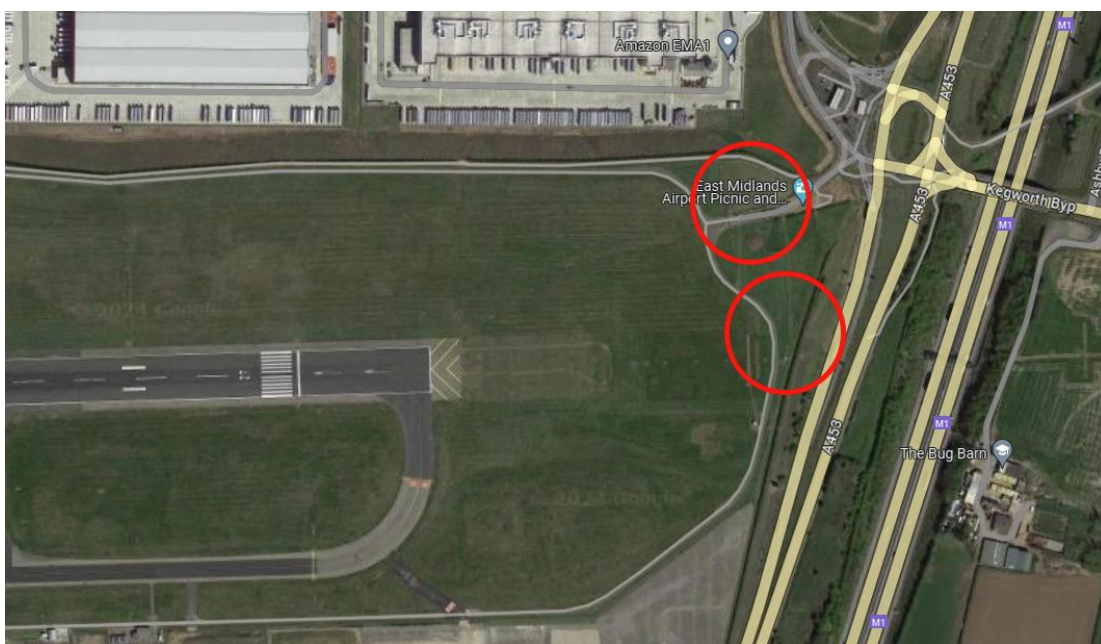
Plane Spotting Locations

Runway 09



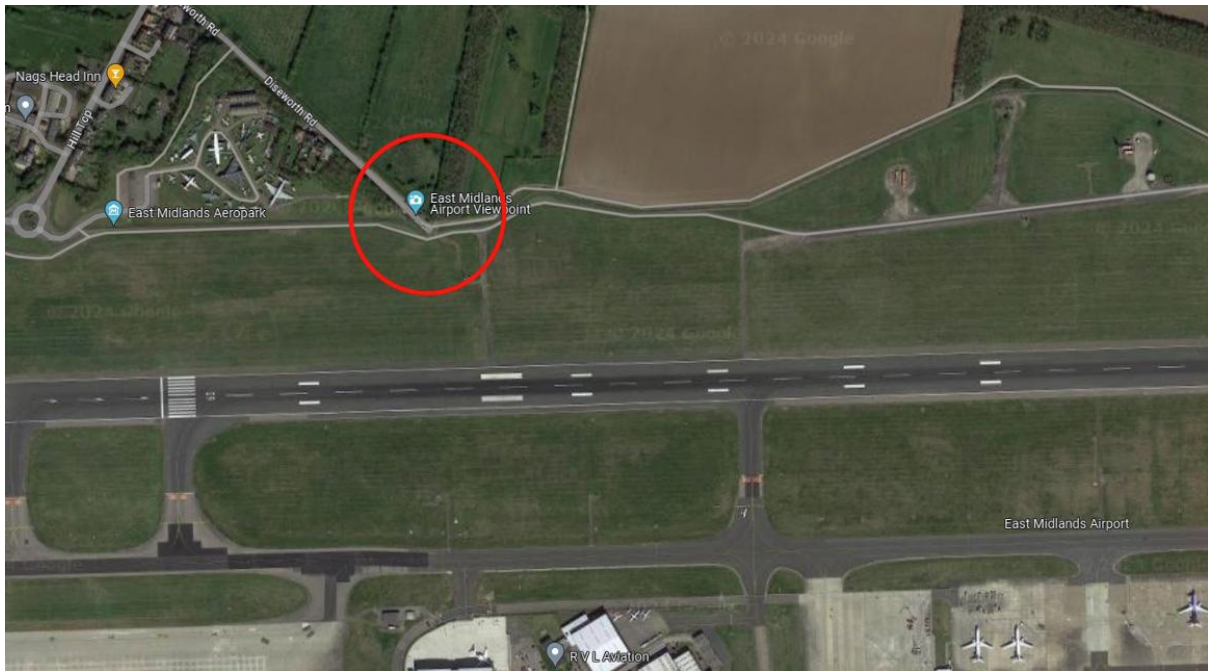
Notice: If you are coming here by car, the parking spot is small so not many cars can be here at once, and the parking spot is at an incline so make sure your car has a good parking brake. In addition, getting off of the parking spot and onto the road can be difficult due to traffic going 50mph from both directions. Although it is worth it as the views you get are amazing. You will get a decent view of the runway. The best part is the cobble platform on the right of the runway

Runway 27



This spot is pretty clean, it has a car park and a picnic area where you can chill and watch the planes land. This part is also closer to the runway; therefore planes will generally fly lower overhead. A good location to film and photograph is the warning sign on the right of the part where the fence turns (next to the approach light). This will give you a decent angle of planes as they are landing.

Not Runway Dependant



Here you will get a nice view of planes taking off and landing from the side. This place also has a trail so that you can adjust your position dependant on the runway side, but it is not required to get a good shot.

Common Planes

This may be out of date by the time you are reading this, but as of May 12th, 2024, these are some planes you can expect to see:

- Ryanair 737-800
- Ryanair 737 MAX 8
- Jet2 737-800
- DHL 757 (less common) *(cargo)*
- DLH 767-300 *(cargo)*
- DLH 777-F *(cargo)*
- UPS 767-300 *(cargo)*
- OneAir 747-400SF (bi-daily to daily basis) *(cargo)*
- TUI 737-800
- TUI 737 MAX 8
- Maersk 767-200 *(cargo)*
- Blue Islands ATR 72-500
- Aer Lingus ATR 72-600

OneAir operates 2 747s out of East Midlands Airport

- G-ONEE
- G-UNET

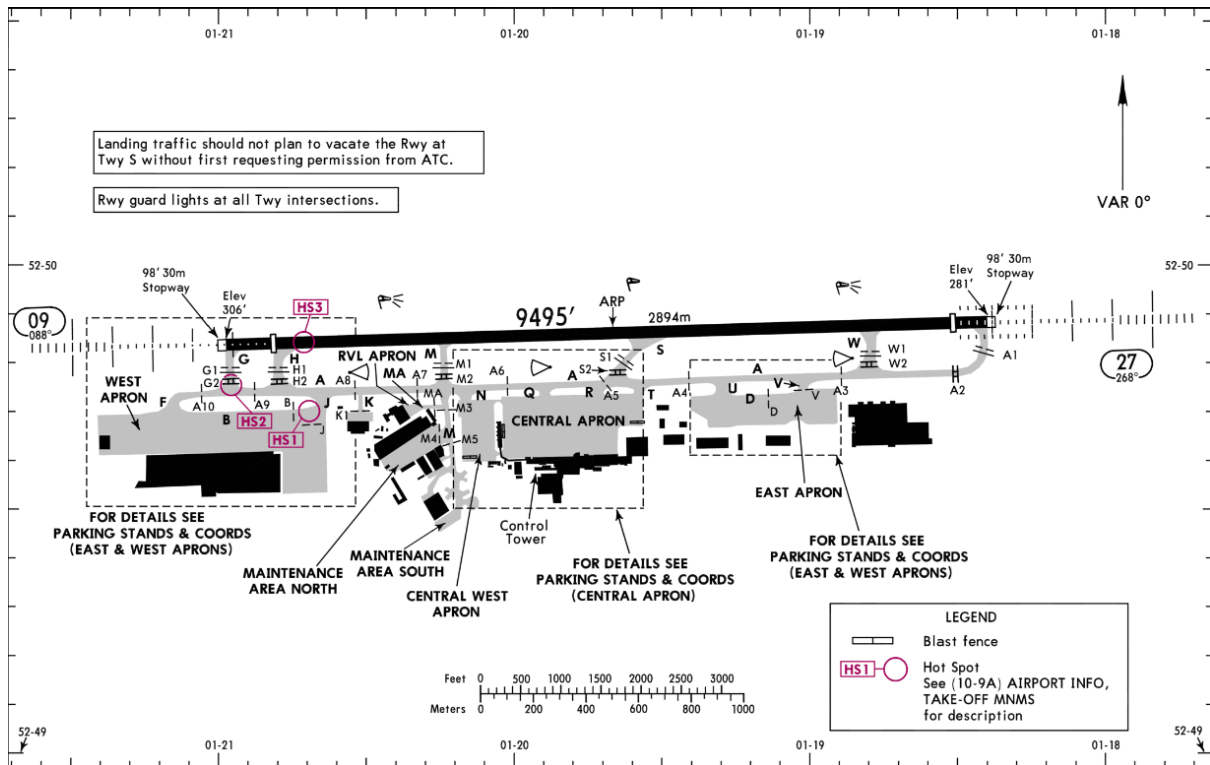
These 2 usually go to Hong Kong however they can go somewhere else. They usually are landing early in the day and taking off later in the evening (or vice versa), you can use FlightRadar24 to find out when its next arrival/departure is. Overall, these planes on departure are susceptible to delays by 10-40 minutes, so if you happen to see one you don't have to rush as it may be delayed. Even if you miss it, you will have another chance in 1-2 days' time. OneAir plans to consistently run these 747s for the distant future, maybe even expanding for more 747s.

ATC Frequencies

If you have a radio scanner, it is a great idea to use, to be able to listen to air traffic control. You want to make sure you have a scanner with the possibility of scanning the aviation frequencies (108mhz to 136mhz)

- East Midlands Ground
 - 121.905
 - This is where aircraft get their taxi clearance to runways or clearance back to the stands. You can listen to this frequency to determine when the aircraft is cleared to taxi or when its requesting pushback. When an aircraft is holding short of a runway ready to take off, they will contact the Tower.
 - East Midlands ATIS
 - 122.680
 - The ATIS (Automatic Terminal Information Service) will tell pilots and you weather information and other stuff. You can listen in to see what active runway is being used etc.
 - East Midlands Tower
 - 124.005
 - The tower is where aircraft get cleared to take off and land. After an aircraft has landed, it will be passed onto Ground to vector them into their stand. Tower can act as ground if Ground is offline (check ATIS)
 - East Midlands Approach
 - 134.175
 - This frequency manages sequencing arriving aircraft and vectoring them onto Final Approach. They do not give landing clearance, they only guide the aircraft until it is on Final Approach, to where then they are passed to the Tower, that give Landing Clearance. They also vector outbound aircraft out of the airport area
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Airport Information



ICAO Code: EGNX

Spotting Tips

Runway 09 in use

If you want to watch take-offs, you can go to the Runway 27 side (the opposite side) this will allow you to see the planes fly directly over you. Depending on how heavy the plane is, it may fly low or if its light, it can be quite high.

For landings, you want to be on the Runway 09 side, onto the hill and then on the little cobblestone platform on the right side facing the runway. This will let you take a good shot of the plane as it is coming in, and you will get to see it touch down.

Runway 27 in use

For that, you just want to do the opposite of what is said for 09. Go to Runway 09 side for take-offs and go to Runway 27 for landings. When Runway 27 is in use, planes will fly over you lower as the fence is closer to the runway at 27 than at 09. However, you could also go to the side part mentioned previously, this is around where the planes will lift off the ground.

General Spotting Tips

Try recording instead of taking photos. Then you can go back into the recording and find a good frame to screenshot. Now you have both the recording and a good photo.

If you are recording, try not to look at the plane through your screen, and try actually see it with our own eyes. If you are just looking through the screen, it defeats the whole purpose of being out there, if you are just going to watch planes through a screen. Try and guide your camera to the plane, you can glance back and forward from the screen if you wish.

Prepare, as planes are very loud. Make sure you dress appropriately for the weather.

Be prepared for runway changes, I recommend having the "METAR" app on your phone.

Be prepared to wait for nothing. East Midlands airport can be busy, but it can also be completely empty and inactive. Be patient, the best spots come when you wait.

Radio Scanners

If you want to use a Radio Scanner, there are some things you should know:

While technically listening to ATC is illegal, the law is barely enforced, and nobody really cares.

“Technically yes and that is due to an old law dating back to wartime but to be honest, there are so many people who do it nowadays – it is highly unlikely people will get done for it. Not impossible of course but very unlikely I would say. Anyone transmitting though, would be in a lot of trouble with the law. It should be noted that it is not illegal to buy, sell or own scanners capable of receiving such frequencies – as you have seen they can easily be purchased online. It is illegal also to redistribute ATC frequencies in the UK which is why liveatc is not a thing here.” –Stuart, Mentour Pilot Community Mod

So, you should not be worried about using a radio scanner to listen to ATC.

Radio Scanners are amazing, if you know basic ATC phraseology, then this tool will be amazing for you. You will be able to hear any incoming/outgoing aircraft being cleared for landing/take-off, and it increases your situational awareness on what is going on in the air.

Now for a scanner I personally use and recommend, it's the [Radtel RT-470X](#), it's cheap (~£36), and it is physically impossible to transmit on the ATC Frequency, so you won't get done for accidentally pressing the talk button. It has dual channel features which means you can listen to 2 frequencies at once. (I personally listen to Tower and Approach) It also has a flashlight built into it and from my experience, the battery life is very good.

ATC Phraseology

“ILS Approach”: ILS stands for Instrument Landing System, which means when ATC says this, they usually mean that an aircraft is clear to approach a runway using the ILS. The ILS sends out beams to the aircraft that help it stay on course during landing.

“Hold Short”: Usually means to wait at a certain point before entering the runway. This point is known as a Hold Short Line and it’s a line on the taxiway that aircraft stop at until further clearance.

“Flight Level xx”: When you hear Flight Level and then 2 numbers that just means altitude. For example, Flight Level 230 would be 23,000ft, Flight Level 070 would be 7,000ft and Flight Level 360 would be 36,000ft and so on. However, flight level isn’t used at low altitudes (ATC will just say the full altitude)

“Glideslope”: The descent path the aircraft has to the touchdown zone on the runway.

“Localiser”: An imaginary line from the runway centreline that spans outwards. For example, if a plane captures localiser, that means they are just flying on the runway centreline on final approach.

Photography on Cameras

Depending on what time of day and what lighting you have available, you will have to adapt your camera settings. Due to the nature of plane spotting, I advise that you do not use Auto mode on your camera.

Here are some general settings for your camera

Condition	Shutter Speed	Aperture	ISO
Sunny Day	1/4000	f4 to f5.6	ISO 200
Cloudy	1/3000	f4	ISO 400
Overcast	1/1000	f4	ISO 400
Dark	1/500	Lowest	ISO 3200
Night	1/500	Lowest	ISO 6400

Unless you have a really good camera then forget about good quality night photos. You can use denoise on lightroom but it will impact photo quality.

Recommended Lenses:

Scenario	Lens
Regular	70-200mm
From distance	400mm
Avoid	18-55mm 24-70mm Or anything under 70mm base

Reason why you shouldn't use those lenses is because the focal length is too short for you to be able to capture planes from distance. However, they will work fine in close range shots. Reason why you should avoid them is because they only work in close range scenarios, and even then a 70-200mm will do the job.

My personal camera recommendation:

Canon R6 Mark III

Great mirrorless camera

If you want something that wont require you to sell a kidney

Canon EOS 700D, Canon EOS 90D or 80D

And buy used cameras, as long as you get a good one you will never notice the difference.
